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[GS I - GEOGRAPHY | GS II - GOVERNANCE | GS III - ENVIRONMENT] | **Publication Date: 23/08/2026**

Ken–Betwa Link Project (KBLP)



Ken–Betwa Link Project transfers water to drought-prone Bundelkhand, improving irrigation, drinking-water supply and energy generation while balancing rehabilitation and environmental protection.

Ken–Betwa Link Project (KBLP)

Syllabus Areas:

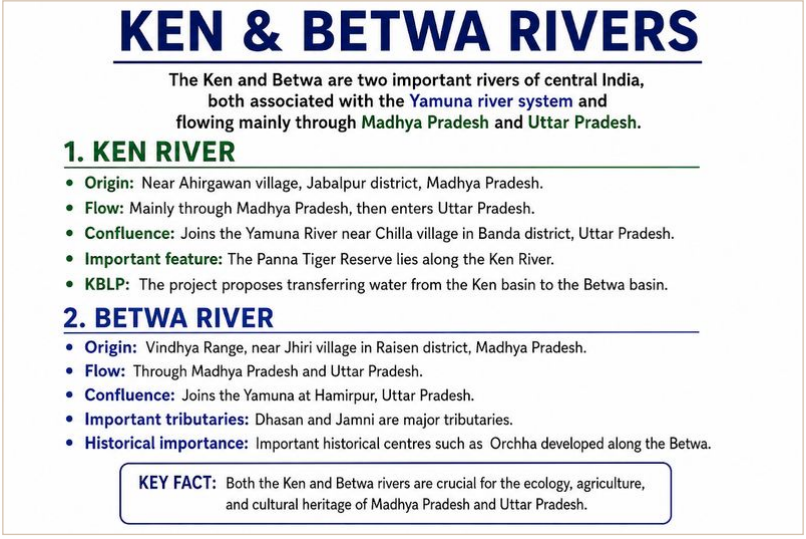
GS I - Geography

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The **Ken–Betwa Link Project (KBLP)** is a major water-resources development project aimed at addressing the **long-standing water scarcity and irrigation challenges of the Bundelkhand region** of Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh.

The project envisages **transfer of water from the Ken River basin to the Betwa River basin** through the construction of the **Daudhan Dam, a link canal and associated works**. It is the **first priority project under the National Perspective Plan for Interlinking of Rivers (ILR)**.



Why is the Ken–Betwa Project Needed?

The **Bundelkhand region** has historically faced:

- Recurrent water scarcity
- Dependence on rainfall
- Groundwater depletion in several areas
- Inadequate irrigation facilities
- Agricultural vulnerability
- Water insecurity for rural communities

The project seeks to provide **more dependable water availability for irrigation and drinking purposes**, thereby strengthening regional water security and reducing vulnerability to drought.

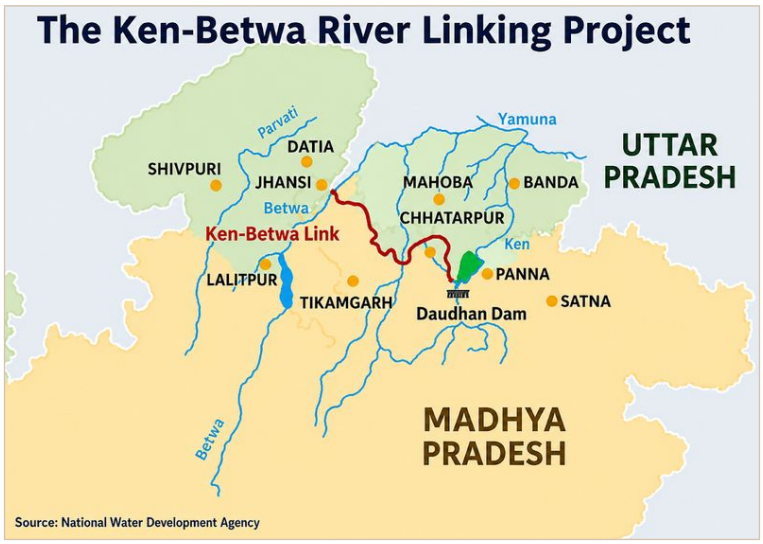


Major Benefits

- **Irrigation:** Provides irrigation to approximately **10.62 lakh hectares**, improving water reliability, cropping intensity, productivity and farm incomes while reducing drought vulnerability.
- **Drinking Water:** Supplies drinking water to around **62 lakh people**, strengthening household water security, public health, sanitation and rural livelihoods, while reducing women's time burden.
- **Renewable Energy:** Generates **103 MW of hydropower** and **27 MW of solar power**, integrating water infrastructure with clean-energy generation.

Areas Benefited

The project will benefit water-stressed areas of **Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh**.



Impact on Agriculture

- **Reliable irrigation** !' Higher cropping intensity & productivity.
- **Crop diversification** !' Higher-value crops & farm incomes.
- **Greater drought resilience** !' Improved rural livelihoods.

Can KBLP Eliminate Drought?

- **No, it cannot completely eliminate drought.**
- Improves **water security, irrigation & drinking-water availability**.
- Reduces vulnerability to **rainfall variability**.
- Outcomes depend on **local hydrogeology & sustainable groundwater use**.

Wider Regional Development

- Boosts **agriculture & employment**.
- Improves **infrastructure, markets, schools & healthcare access**.
- Promotes **commercial and agro-industrial development**.

Transportation: Key Clarification

- KBLP is primarily a **water-resource & energy project**, not a transport corridor.
- Project roads, bridges & access infrastructure can improve **local connectivity**.
- Supports movement of **people, goods and agricultural produce** and access to markets/services.



Land Acquisition and Rehabilitation & Resettlement

Land is required for the Daudhan Dam, Ken–Betwa Link Canal, powerhouses, roads and related infrastructure. Acquisition follows the **RFCTLARR Act, 2013** and state laws, covering affected landowners, livelihood-dependent persons and forest communities.

- **Compensation & Special R&R Package:** A special R&R package was announced in 2023. **Rs. 629.87 crore** was awarded, **Rs. 604.745 crore** paid, covering **5,039 affected families**, with approximately 96% disbursed.
- **Livelihood Restoration:** Rehabilitation extends beyond compensation, providing affected families **vocational training, skill development, financial assistance, SHG support and small-business assistance** to restore livelihoods and improve economic opportunities.
- **Special Provisions for Vulnerable Communities:** Eligible **SC/ST families and families in Scheduled Areas** receive additional assistance. Rights of tribal and forest-dependent communities are protected under the **Forest Rights Act, 2006**.
- **Environmental Concerns:** KBLP incorporates **EIA, Environmental Management Plans, wildlife and forest safeguards, compensatory afforestation, biodiversity conservation and landscape planning**, supported by required environmental, wildlife and forest clearances.

Panna Tiger Reserve: Major Environmental Dimension

One of the most important environmental issues associated with KBLP is its proximity to the **Panna Tiger Reserve (PTR)** and the associated forest and biodiversity impacts.

The project has addressed these concerns through landscape-level planning and conservation measures.

Measures mentioned in the document

- **Integrated Landscape Management Plan (ILMP)** by the Wildlife Institute of India
- **Greater Panna Landscape Management Plan**
- Safeguarding species such as:
- Tiger
- Vulture
- Gharial

These measures seek to address impacts on forest ecosystems and biodiversity while ensuring long-term conservation.

- **Compensatory Afforestation:** Where forest land is diverted for approved project purposes, **compensatory afforestation and other prescribed measures** are undertaken in accordance with applicable forest legislation.

The objective is to compensate for unavoidable forest loss and contribute to **long-term ecological restoration**

Downstream Water Security

The project is also designed to maintain environmental and downstream water requirements.

According to the document, **continuous minimum environmental water release** is to be maintained around the year so that:

- Downstream farming is supported
- Drinking-water needs are met
- Aquatic ecosystems remain undisturbed
- Regional groundwater recharge is supported

Thus, downstream ecological and livelihood concerns are incorporated into the project's water-management framework.

KBLP illustrates India's effort to convert water-stressed regions into more resilient development zones while demonstrating the need to integrate environmental safeguards, community rights and rehabilitation into large infrastructure projects.